FREE GUIDE 05 · BOUNDARIES AND OWNERSHIP

How to Say No Without Losing Trust

Respond to an unrealistic request with a clear constraint, a useful alternative and an agreed decision.

Every yes spends time that may already belong to something else.

A trustworthy response makes capacity and consequences visible early. You can be helpful without pretending every deadline is possible. The aim is a feasible agreement, while recognizing that you cannot control how another person reacts.

Start here

Pick a request you are struggling to accept. Write the requested outcome, deadline and estimated effort. Then name the commitment that would move if you said yes.

01 Acknowledge the goal

02 Name the constraint

03 Offer an alternative

04 Agree the choice

Set aside 15 minutes. Work through the examples, then print page 4 for your own situation.

SEE IT IN PRACTICE

From a familiar response to a useful one.

Fictional examples for practice. Adapt the reasoning to the facts of your situation.

AN IMPOSSIBLE DEADLINE

Before: No, we are too busy.

After: I understand you need this for Friday’s decision. The full analysis needs two days; we have one available. I can deliver the two highest-risk scenarios Friday and the full analysis Tuesday. Would the smaller version support Friday’s decision?

You acknowledge the purpose, explain the constraint and test a useful alternative. The reduced scope is explicit.

A NEW TOP PRIORITY

Before: Sure, we will find a way.

After: We can take this on. It needs about eight hours, which would move the customer review from Thursday to Monday. I recommend protecting the customer review and starting this Friday. If the new request takes priority, can we agree that change with the review owner today?

You bring the affected commitment into the conversation before it is missed. You are not quietly making another stakeholder absorb the cost.

WORK OUTSIDE THE TEAM’S AUTHORITY

Before: That is not my job.

After: I can help frame the issue and share the evidence. The approval sits with Finance, so I cannot commit their budget. Let us take the options to the budget owner. I can prepare the brief by Wednesday.

You distinguish help you can offer from authority you do not have. A useful boundary can still move work forward.

THE METHOD

Prepare the boundary before the wording.

Check the real requirement

Ask what the request enables, when the decision is needed and which parts are essential. A shorter deliverable may solve the actual problem.

Describe capacity concretely

Use available hours, dependencies or existing commitments. An estimate can be a range. Say what you still need to confirm rather than presenting a guess as a fact.

Offer a credible alternative

Change scope, sequence, deadline or qualified capacity. Make sure the alternative is yours to offer. Do not solve one conflict by making an unapproved promise to someone else.

Agree who chooses

If priorities conflict beyond your authority, take the options and consequences to the right decision maker. Confirm what moves, who informs the affected people, and when the plan will be reviewed.

Keep this to hand

I understand the goal is [outcome] by [date]. The constraint is [capacity, dependency or authority]. We can [option A], which means [trade-off], or [option B]. I recommend [choice]. Can [decision owner] confirm by [time]?

YOUR PRINTABLE WORKSHEET

Prepare your next response.

Use a real, ordinary workplace request. Adapt the wording to your role and relationship; no script guarantees agreement.

01 The outcome the requester needs and the deadline

02 Available capacity, dependencies and decision authority

03 What would move or suffer if I said yes?

04 Two feasible alternatives and the consequence of each

05 My recommendation and the decision owner

06 The words I will use, plus the follow-up agreement

TAKE IT INTO YOUR WEEK

One useful next move.

Before you use it

Read your completed sheet once. Check each statement below.

- [ ] I understand the outcome behind the request.
- [ ] The constraint is specific and honest.
- [ ] My alternative is feasible and within my authority.
- [ ] Affected people will hear about any changed commitment.

Try it once

Use the structure in one low-stakes conversation. Ask the other person which part is essential. Afterward, confirm the agreed scope and date in writing. Check whether the agreement held and what you learned about estimating or communicating the constraint.

Afterward, ask yourself

What did we agree to protect? What moved? Did everyone affected know?

Practice the decisions behind the words.

The Step Up to Senior Leadership course develops recommendations, trade-offs, influence and ownership through twelve practical lessons. The first module is free after login on TagMango.

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